



**Biding time:** Sunrisers Hyderabad has invested in developing talents like Abhishek Sharma, who needed three years to become a consistent performer. K. R. DEEPAK

Giants, Mumbai Indians, and Sunrisers Hyderabad — retained five players each. Meanwhile, Delhi Capitals, Royal Challengers Bengaluru, and Punjab Kings chose to retain four, three, and two players, respectively.

Entering the mega auction in Jeddah with Rs 110.5 crore, Punjab Kings holds the largest purse, allowing it the opportunity to

regroup and build a new team. However, it also poses challenges for franchises like Kolkata Knight Riders and Delhi Capitals, who risk losing stars like Shreyas Iyer and Rishabh Pant to the auction pool.

Delhi Capitals co-owner Parth Jindal expressed strong support for mega auctions during the meeting, arguing that they create a level playing field. "I was surprised there was a debate. Some argued there should be no mega auction at all, only smaller auctions, but I'm not in that camp," Jindal said. "I feel it evens the playing field and keeps the IPL competitive."

Punjab Kings co-owner Ness

Wadia agreed, asserting that regular auctions ultimately benefit all stakeholders. "It's the biggest league in the world, and we need to maintain high standards," Wadia said.

Reflecting this view, Punjab Kings retained only two uncapped players — Shashank Singh and Prabhsimran Singh — and will approach the auction with a fresh strategy under new head coach Ricky Ponting.

This year, the BCCI revised the retention rules to adjust for a purse of Rs 120 crore, a 20 per cent increase from last year. Retaining the first player costs a team Rs 18 crore, while the second and third players